

COMPLETE CHESS LEARNING LIBRARY

The Complete Pirc and Modern Defense

Flexible development against 1.e4, central breaks, and counterattacking structures

TRAINING WORKBOOK

20 focused chapters - model positions - decision rules - retrieval practice

Designed to change what you notice, calculate, remember, and do at the board.

Workbook Method

Attempt each page before reopening the matching course-book chapter. Speak answers aloud or write them. The self-score rewards a clear decision rule and the opponent's best reply, not a lucky move guess.

REVIEW THRESHOLD

8-10: review in one week. 5-7: review tomorrow. 0-4: reread the course chapter now, then retry from a blank board.

Use the workbook again after a game reaches a related structure. Real-game retrieval is the final test.

01. Pirc Core Setup - Stage 1



PIRC FOUNDATION

POSITION PROMPT

Black has invited a two-pawn center while developing toward a fianchetto.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 d6 2. d4 Nf6 3. Nc3 g6

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

4. Which piece has the least useful job?

5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

02. Pirc Core Setup - Stage 2



PIRC FOUNDATION

POSITION PROMPT

Black is castled, but White's center still demands a timely challenge.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 d6 2. d4 Nf6 3. Nc3 g6 4. Nf3 Bg7 5. Be2 O-O

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

03. Classical Pirc with ...e5 - Stage 1



PIRC CLASSICAL

POSITION PROMPT

Black has challenged d4 in a normally developed Classical Pirc.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 d6 2. d4 Nf6 3. Nc3 g6 4. Nf3 Bg7 5. Be2 O-O 6. O-O e5

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?
-
2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.
-
3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?
-
4. Which piece has the least useful job?
-
5. What ending would favor you, and why?
-

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

04. Classical Pirc with ...e5 - Stage 2



PIRC CLASSICAL

POSITION PROMPT

Central exchanges have reduced White's space and opened files.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 d6 2. d4 Nf6 3. Nc3 g6 4. Nf3 Bg7 5. Be2 O-O 6. O-O e5 7. Re1 exd4 8. Nxd4

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

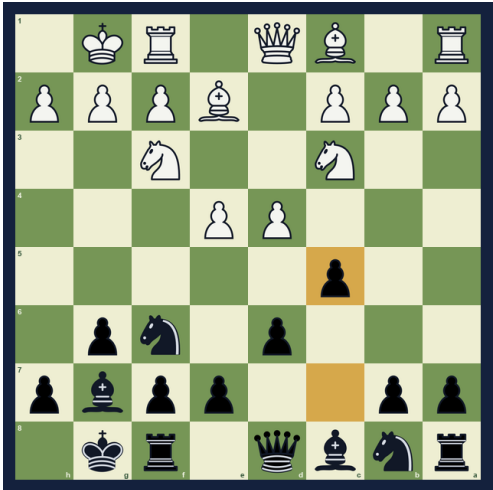
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

05. Pirc with ...c5 - Stage 1



PIRC CENTRAL BREAKS

POSITION PROMPT

Black has attacked d4 from the flank with ...c5.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 d6 2. d4 Nf6 3. Nc3 g6 4. Nf3 Bg7 5. Be2 O-O 6. O-O c5

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?
-
2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.
-
3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?
-
4. Which piece has the least useful job?
-
5. What ending would favor you, and why?
-

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

06. Pirc with ...c5 - Stage 2



PIRC CENTRAL BREAKS

POSITION PROMPT

White has advanced d5 and Black is challenging the pawn chain with ...e6.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 d6 2. d4 Nf6 3. Nc3 g6 4. Nf3 Bg7 5. Be2 O-O 6. O-O c5 7. d5 e6

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?
-
2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.
-
3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?
-
4. Which piece has the least useful job?
-
5. What ending would favor you, and why?
-

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

07. Austrian Attack - Stage 1



PIRC WHITE SYSTEMS

POSITION PROMPT

White has built an aggressive d4-e4-f4 center.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 d6 2. d4 Nf6 3. Nc3 g6 4. f4 Bg7 5. Nf3 O-O

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

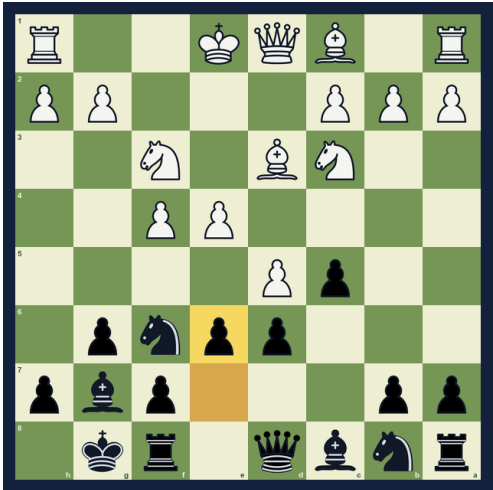
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

08. Austrian Attack - Stage 2



PIRC WHITE SYSTEMS

POSITION PROMPT

Black has struck at d4 and d5 before White completes the attack.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 d6 2. d4 Nf6 3. Nc3 g6 4. f4 Bg7 5. Nf3 O-O 6. Bd3 c5 7. d5 e6

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

09. 150 Attack - Stage 1



PIRC WHITE SYSTEMS

POSITION PROMPT

White has built the Be3-Qd2 battery and is preparing long castling.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 d6 2. d4 Nf6 3. Nc3 g6 4. Be3 Bg7 5. Qd2 O-O 6. f3

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

10. 150 Attack - Stage 2



PIRC WHITE SYSTEMS

POSITION PROMPT

Both sides have begun a direct opposite-wing race.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 d6 2. d4 Nf6 3. Nc3 g6 4. Be3 Bg7 5. Qd2 O-O 6. f3 c6 7. O-O-O b5 8. h4

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

11. Classical Pirc with ...c6 - Stage 1



PIRC CLASSICAL

POSITION PROMPT

Black has used ...c6 to support flexible central and queenside play.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 d6 2. d4 Nf6 3. Nc3 g6 4. Nf3 Bg7 5. Be2 O-O 6. O-O c6

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?
-
2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.
-
3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?
-
4. Which piece has the least useful job?
-
5. What ending would favor you, and why?
-

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

12. Classical Pirc with ...c6 - Stage 2



PIRC CLASSICAL

POSITION PROMPT

White has restrained ...b5, and Black has developed the knight through a6.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 d6 2. d4 Nf6 3. Nc3 g6 4. Nf3 Bg7 5. Be2 O-O 6. O-O c6 7. a4 a5 8. Re1 Na6

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

13. Early Bishop Systems - Stage 1



PIRC WHITE SYSTEMS

POSITION PROMPT

White's early Bg5 creates pins and discourages comfortable central breaks.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 d6 2. d4 Nf6 3. Nc3 g6 4. Bg5 Bg7

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

14. Early Bishop Systems - Stage 2



PIRC WHITE SYSTEMS

POSITION PROMPT

White's Be3-Qd2 battery signals pressure on the fianchetto.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 d6 2. d4 Nf6 3. Nc3 g6 4. Be3 Bg7 5. Qd2 O-O

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

15. Pirc f3 Systems - Stage 1



PIRC WHITE SYSTEMS

POSITION PROMPT

White has reinforced e4 with f3 and kept several attacking setups available.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 d6 2. d4 Nf6 3. Nc3 g6 4. f3 Bg7 5. Be3

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

16. Pirc f3 Systems - Stage 2



PIRC WHITE SYSTEMS

POSITION PROMPT

White has castled long and Black has begun queenside expansion.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 d6 2. d4 Nf6 3. Nc3 g6 4. f3 Bg7 5. Be3 O-O 6. Qd2 c6 7. O-O-O b5

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

17. Pirc Queenside Counterplay - Stage 1



PIRC ATTACKING PLAY

POSITION PROMPT

Black has prepared queenside expansion while White prepares long castling.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 d6 2. d4 Nf6 3. Nc3 g6 4. Be3 Bg7 5. Qd2 O-O 6. f3 c6

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

18. Pirc Queenside Counterplay - Stage 2



PIRC ATTACKING PLAY

POSITION PROMPT

...b4 has gained space and attacked the c3-knight near White's king.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 d6 2. d4 Nf6 3. Nc3 g6 4. Be3 Bg7 5. Qd2 O-O 6. f3 c6 7. O-O-O b5 8. h4 b4

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

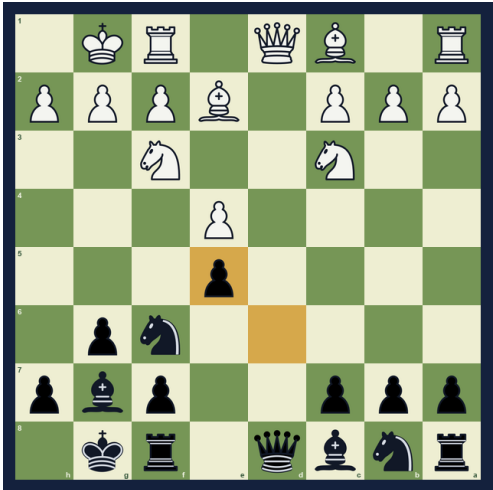
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

19. Pirc Central Simplification - Stage 1



PIRC ENDGAMES

POSITION PROMPT

White has exchanged in the center and reduced the attacking character.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 d6 2. d4 Nf6 3. Nc3 g6 4. Nf3 Bg7 5. Be2 O-O 6. O-O e5 7. dxe5 dxe5

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

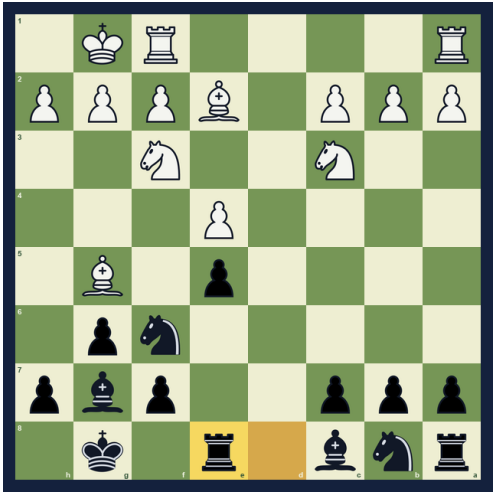
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

20. Pirc Central Simplification - Stage 2



PIRC ENDGAMES

POSITION PROMPT

Queens are off and Black has centralized a rook in a playable endgame.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 d6 2. d4 Nf6 3. Nc3 g6 4. Nf3 Bg7 5. Be2 O-O 6. O-O e5 7. dxe5 dxe5 8. Qxd8 Rxd8 9. Bg5 Re8

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

Monthly Retention Audit

Select ten random chapters and complete them under a ten-minute total limit. Track the categories you repeatedly miss: threat, candidate, structure, piece job, or forecast.

Do not restart the entire course. Return to the smallest group of chapters that repairs the repeated error, then test again in one week.